Chris **Hickman**

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Summary

Backend engineer with 3+ years shipping production systems at Walmart scale, including agentic AI features for Sparky: Walmart's AI shopping assistant serving 1M+ daily customers. Specialized in Java/Spring Boot microservices, distributed systems, and Kafka. Owned features end-to-end from design through production, with measurable revenue impact.

Technical Skills

Languages: Java (8-21), Kotlin, Python, JavaScript
Backend: Spring Boot, Kafka, REST APIs, Microservices
Frontend: React, HTML, CSS
DevOps: CI/CD, Kubernetes, Jenkins, Maven, Gradle
Cloud & Data: Azure CosmosDB, GCP (BigQuery, AlloyDB), PostgreSQL
Monitoring: Grafana, Splunk
Tools: IntelliJ IDEA, Postman, Git

Work Experience

April 2025 – Present

Software Engineer III – Sparky AI @ Walmart Emerging Tech, Hoboken NJ

Backend engineer on Walmart's agentic AI shopping assistant, owning features end-to-end across design, implementation, and production release in a high-velocity Java 21/Spring Boot environment.

- Led end-to-end engineering for the **Essentials Experience**: shipping to Sparky's **1M+** DAU production platform, validated by A/B testing, and drove Add-To-Cart by **3.8%** through agentic product discovery for high-frequency everyday items.
- Built **Sponsored Products** carousel integration, enabling **monetized AI-driven placements** in the product discovery experience; shipped to A/B test within my first month on the Sparky team.
- Reduced p99 latency by **75%** in the Essentials everyday staples experience by identifying and eliminating redundant AI router calls in the request path.
- Introduced E2E, linting, and functional test coverage into the CI/CD pipeline, improving **production readiness** and defect catch rate for a high-velocity AI feature team.

February 2023 – April 2025

Software Engineer II – Catalog @ Walmart Global Tech, Hoboken NJ

Enhanced and maintained Walmart's product setup pipeline, ensuring accurate product matching and catalog integrity. Built and optimized scalable, high-performance systems critical to product setup, including Matching and Normalization, through rigorous system design and test-driven development.

- **Modernized** mission-critical Product Merge and Split APIs via **zero-downtime migration** from Java 8 to Java 21 and Spring Boot 3.x, validating data integrity across millions of catalog transactions using shadow mode before full cutover.
- Designed and optimized RESTful APIs in a **microservice** environment with JUnit and Mockito test coverage, improving data retrieval efficiency and system reliability.
- Built and maintained **Kafka**-based event-driven microservices within a distributed systems architecture, processing 1M+ product changes daily and integrating with GCP storage solutions.

Education

BS Computer Science, Clarkson University - Potsdam, NY | Dec 2022 GPA: 3.86

- Strong foundation in algorithms, software design, and OOP (Java, C++). Graduated with great distinction.

AAS Graphic Art and Design, NCCC – Malone NY | May 2020 GPA: 3.944

- Mastered design principles, UI/UX concepts, and the Adobe Suite. President of the Art Club for two semesters.